

Nefertiti, Tutankhamun and Ramses II

Three names are particularly associated with spectacular Egyptian art. Nefertiti was the Great Royal Wife of Akhenaten, the 'heretic' Pharaoh who promoted the worship of just one god and encouraged more realism in art. Her famous painted limestone bust, attributed to the sculptor Thutmose and made in 1345 BCE, features a stylized long slender neck, and subtle naturalism, including fine lines beneath her eyes. Akhenaten's son Tutankhamun ruled Egypt for just a decade until his early death aged 19. His tomb, discovered in 1922, contained many richly embellished artefacts. His solid gold mummy mask, inlaid with semi-precious stones, glass and faience, depicts him wearing a *nemes*, or head-cloth, adorned with the heads of a vulture and cobra – symbols of Upper and Lower Egypt. Its idealized face adheres to older Egyptian tradition.

About a century later, Ramses II (Ramesses the Great) built huge temples and palaces, illustrated his military victories on reliefs, and erected colossal statues of himself.



Thuthmose, Bust of Nefertiti, 1345 BCE